

Afternoon Discoveries

September 25, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Creative Nonfiction, Memoir, Essays, & Narrative Journalism

There are many ways for nonfiction to tell us what happened. The more interesting question is what a writer does with what happened once memory, distance, doubt, research, and language have all had their turn.

Today's discoveries move through the body, family history, money, art, addiction, cities, sound, imprisonment, and the strange machinery of memory. Some are deeply personal while others report outward into systems and

communities. The best of them keep finding places where those two directions meet.

All links were checked against the linked publication, publisher, or magazine page on September 25, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Elizabeth Alexander on Finding Life in the Second Spring of Middle Age - Elizabeth Alexander

In an excerpt from *Signals Across Vast Distances: Essays and Tales*, published today by Literary Hub, Elizabeth Alexander looks back at the years when dance trained her body and considers what that training left behind in her writing. Precision, line, pace, self-assessment, strength, the ability to change direction without losing form. The vocabulary of movement gradually becomes a vocabulary for making art.

Then the essay turns toward middle age. The body remembers what it once knew even as it changes, and Alexander considers the possibility that an earlier self is not simply something we leave behind. Some parts may return differently, carrying what the years between have taught them.

There is a lovely patience to the piece. It does not insist that aging restores what was lost. It asks instead what might become available when experience meets an old form of courage.

[Read at Literary Hub](#)

The Discovery Desk

Still On Its Way to Cleveland - Mark Blondin and Betsy Blondin

In 1996, Mark and Betsy Blondin left Michigan in a motorhome with three children, a golden retriever, a computer bolted where a chair used to be, and an unusual plan: travel the United States while documenting the journey online.

Nine months, roughly 25,000 miles, and 40 states later, their family had built something that existed before anyone quite knew what to call it. Google was still two years away. The word “blog” had not yet been coined. Their dispatches travelled through borrowed phone jacks and dial-up connections.

Thirty years later, the original website is still there.

That makes this Longreads feature more than a road-trip memoir. It is also a small history of an internet built around curiosity, human recommendation, and the generosity of strangers. The technology dates the journey, but the family looking backward gives it its weight.

[Read at Longreads](#)

On Not Being a Homeowner - Anna Holmes

Anna Holmes begins with houses she remembers.

From there, an essay about property becomes an essay about family, friendship, class, race, inheritance, security, and the quiet arithmetic that separates people whose lives might otherwise look economically similar.

Holmes traces her parents' experiences with housing, her mother's finances, her own years of renting, and the increasingly visible role that family wealth plays in who can buy. What gives the piece its force is that she does not write from a tidy position outside the subject. Envy, nostalgia, frustration, gratitude, and desire are all allowed into the room.

A house is an asset, but it is also a place where someone once sat on the carpet and played.

The essay keeps both truths in view.

[Read at The New Yorker](#)

My Two Front Teeth - Joshua Bodwell

A damaged tooth can be repaired, but the story remains.

Joshua Bodwell uses a lifetime of dental trouble as the thread through a much larger personal history. Childhood, family instability, money, embarrassment, appearance, and the peculiar intimacy of being examined in a dentist's chair accumulate around those two front teeth.

It is an effective memoir structure because the recurring object is so ordinary. Yet, each return to the mouth opens another period of a life until what first looks like a story about dental drama has become a way of measuring time.

[Read at The American Scholar](#)

No, But - Dennis M. Hogan

What happened to improv?

Dennis M. Hogan starts with a form built around not knowing what comes next; a suggestion from an audience, a group of performers, and the agreement that whatever appears has to be carried forward.

From there *No, But* looks at the history and machinery that grew around improvisational comedy, including the long-form structures meant to turn spontaneous scenes into something coherent. There is an interesting tension underneath the whole piece. How much structure does spontaneity need before the structure begins to swallow it?

It is partly cultural history, partly criticism, and partly an examination of what happens when an art form develops systems for teaching people how to be unpredictable.

Read at The Baffler

*The expanded edition includes six more discoveries, three pieces from **Beyond the First Shelf**, and today's **Special Recommendations**.*

All support goes towards helping Among the Letter continue to produce articles and is greatly appreciated.

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More From the Discovery Desk

Heaven's Melodic Strains - Colin Vanderburg

There are people who listen to music, and then there are people who move a speaker by two inches and wonder whether the universe has finally aligned.

Colin Vanderburg writes from inside audiophilia rather than observing it from a safe distance. His essay for *n+1* moves through the history, technology, absurdities, arguments, and genuine pleasures of extreme listening, eventually arriving at the New York International Audio Show and equipment whose prices can wander comfortably into six figures.

The gear is entertaining, but the deeper question is better: what exactly are we pursuing when we try to reproduce sound perfectly?

A recording is already a representation. Every machine between source and listener introduces another decision about what fidelity means. Vanderburg turns that technical problem into a personal one about attention, obsession, perception, and the things we convince ourselves we can hear.

Read at *n+1*

A Tale of Two Trap Houses: Being Cuckooed Ruined My Friend's Life - But Did It Then Help Save Him? - Max Daly

Max Daly reports on “cuckooing”, the practice of drug gangs taking over the homes of vulnerable people, through the life of someone he has known for decades.

His friend Duncan experienced it twice.

The first takeover helped dismantle an already fragile life. The second became far more complicated. Exploitation, addiction, criminality, routine, companionship, and what Duncan himself understands as friendship became entangled in ways that refuse a simple victim-and-predator narrative.

Daly does not make the contradictions disappear. That is what makes the reporting worth spending time with. The piece remains attentive both to the structures that make vulnerable people easy to exploit and to Duncan's own account of a relationship outsiders may find difficult to understand.

[Read at The Guardian](#)

Impossibility Is a Myth - Jack Jeffery and Abraham Elton

This piece is highly recommended by the editor, it deeply resonates with some of my own work on philosophy.

In 2021, a vast painting called *The Journey of Humanity* appeared to sell at auction for \$62 million.

Jack Jeffery and Abraham Elton begin with a problem: the reported sale made headlines around the world, but the money never changed hands.

From there, their investigation for *The Fence* follows the artwork, artist Sacha Jafri, buyer André Abdoune, the charitable claims surrounding the auction, and the mythology that accumulated around one spectacular evening in Dubai.

It is a story about an artwork, but also about what happens when reputation, philanthropy, spectacle, wealth, and repetition

become powerful enough to manufacture their own apparent reality.

[Read at The Fence](#)

Where Cities and Oceans Meet - Brad Bolman

Brad Bolman lives in New Orleans and teaches environmental history there. That makes the question at the centre of this essay unusually literal; what does it mean to build a future in a place facing profound environmental uncertainty?

Bolman writes after research on Louisiana's disappearing land renewed discussion about the long-term future of New Orleans. At the same time, he and his partner were considering buying a home.

The essay moves between those scales, from scientific projections, centuries of attempts to control water, inequality, and local attachment, to the very ordinary human act of imagining yourself living somewhere years from now.

It is difficult to think about a city disappearing, but it may be even harder to think about making dinner, buying furniture, knowing your neighbours, and continuing to love it while understanding the threat.

[Read at Pioneer Works Broadcast](#)

O Mother - Emerson Whitney

Going home is one of memoir's oldest movements. Emerson Whitney's *O Mother* begins with a return that was not supposed to happen.

Whitney had built a life at a distance from the rural Maine island where they grew up and from a difficult relationship with their mother. When exhaustion and chronic illness forced a change, home began pulling them back.

The reunion does not become the repair Whitney imagines. The memoir instead moves through family, disability, grief, diagnosis, memory, and the desire to understand another person after understanding can no longer change what happened.

McSweeney's description makes clear that this is not simply a book about returning to one's mother. It is also about confronting the limits of what love can fix.

[Find *O Mother* at McSweeney's](#)

Huna **- Abdelrahman ElGendy**

Published by Hogarth, *Huna* is Abdelrahman ElGendy's debut memoir.

ElGendy recounts being arrested as a teenager alongside his father during the upheaval following Egypt's 2011 revolution and spending the next six years as a political prisoner. Writing, reading, education, family, friendship, and language become part of how the memoir understands those years rather than simply a way of recording them afterward.

The title comes from "Sawfa Nabqa Huna", or "We Will Remain Here". That question of where "here" exists becomes central to

a book concerned not only with confinement, but with what a person can preserve when place, autonomy, and ordinary life have been taken away.

[Find Huna at Penguin Random House](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Making Meaning, One Step at a Time: A Conversation with Earl Swift

A useful craft conversation for anyone who has ever known what a story contains but struggled with how quickly to move through it.

Earl Swift speaks with Brendan O'Meara about reporting and writing *Up on Cove Mountain: Adventure, Tragedy, and a Quest for Meaning on the Appalachian Trail*. Their conversation turns repeatedly to pacing, proportion, structure, truth, and the small obstacles that can make a reader stop.

Swift hiked the Appalachian Trail twice, thirty years apart, before writing the book. That combination of lived experience and reporting makes the conversation particularly interesting for nonfiction writers trying to understand the boundary between having material and shaping it.

[Read the conversation at Longreads](#)

How an Egyptian Prison Poem Came to Structure My Memoir - Abdelrahman ElGendy

If *Huna* is the finished structure, this is a look at part of the architecture underneath it.

ElGendy explains why he wrote the memoir in English, the tensions that created for a story rooted in Arabic language and Egyptian prison life, and how the form of an *anbara* - a prison call-and-response tradition used across cells - helped shape the book.

The piece is especially useful because structure here is not cosmetic. The form becomes connected to who is speaking, who is listening, what can be translated, and what the writer chooses not to make easily accessible.

[Read at Literary Hub](#)

Got Writer's Block? Go to the Theater! - Amy Fusselman

Amy Fusselman's craft piece offers a pleasingly sideways response to creative stagnation: stop staring exclusively at the medium in which you are stuck.

For Fusselman, theater became part of her writing practice because it exposes her to completed decisions about character, dialogue, setting, pacing, and story in a form governed by different constraints. It also provides something a writer rarely gets while working alone: an audience reacting to a narrative in real time.

The broader idea travels well beyond theater. Sometimes another art form gives us access to possibilities we have stopped noticing in our own.

[Read at Literary Hub](#)

Special Recommendations

A few pieces do not need to be new to deserve another afternoon.

Annie Dillard and the Writing Life - Alexander Chee

Alexander Chee remembers studying literary nonfiction with Annie Dillard at Wesleyan.

It is part portrait of a teacher, part account of a young writer being changed by instruction, and part meditation on what can actually be taught about writing. Dillard's classroom emerges through habits, rules, conversations, arguments, and small details that feel preserved because Chee understood, even then, that they mattered.

The result is one of those rare essays about writing instruction that is interesting even if you have no intention of entering a workshop.

[Read at The Morning News](#)

The Crane Wife **- CJ Hauser**

Ten days after calling off an engagement, CJ Hauser leaves for a scientific expedition to study whooping cranes on the Gulf Coast of Texas.

The cranes become only one part of the story.

Hauser writes about the relationship she left, the needs she trained herself not to express, the people around her on the expedition, and the strange relief of discovering that a life can feel more like your own immediately after the future you planned has collapsed.

The essay keeps returning to care - what living things need, what people need, and what happens when needing anything at all begins to feel like a personal failure.

[Read at The Paris Review](#)

Joyas Voladoras **- Brian Doyle**

A hummingbird's heart is tiny and astonishing, and a whale's heart is enormous while also astonishing.

Joyas Voladoras moves through hearts as organs and hearts as the things onto which humans have placed nearly every metaphor for love, fear, endurance, loneliness, and loss. It is short enough to read almost accidentally and carefully enough written that individual sentences can stay around for years.

Some essays accumulate their meaning through argument; this one moves by association, rhythm, scale, and a gradual

narrowing toward something painfully human.

If you have never read it, there is a reason it continues to be passed from reader to reader.

Read at [The American Scholar](#)

*Thank you for spending part of your day wandering through the letters with us.
Whether you found one piece to read tonight or several to keep open for later, I
hope something here leads you on a wondrous adventure.*

Take care!